

AREHEARSAL STAGED ON THE WRONG SET

INDIA'S NINTH ASIA CUP CROWN OFFERED DOMINANCE WITHOUT A TRUE TEST, WITH SLUGGISH UAE PITCHES AND FALTERING RIVALS PROVIDING LITTLE REHEARSAL FOR THE FLAT TRACKS AND STRONGER OPPOSITION AWAITING AT THE T20 WORLD CUP.

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The Asia Cup is not an end in itself. With the biennial continental event alternating between formats since 2016, it now serves as a dress rehearsal for teams to fine-tune their combinations ahead of a major International Cricket Council (ICC) event. For Suryakumar Yadav and Co., it was an opportunity to test a young side and its high-intent approach in the cauldron of a multi-team tournament ahead of India's T20 World Cup defence at home early next year.

A dry run is most effective when it closely mirrors the conditions of the event one is preparing for, and the Asia Cup in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) was a far cry in that regard. The sluggish pitches and subcontinental teams that are struggling to adapt to an aggressive brand of batting didn't reflect the flat decks and sterner opposition

the Men in Blue are likely to be confronted with at next year's showpiece.

India clinched a record-extending ninth Asia Cup title, edging Pakistan in a tense final in Dubai, and had to dig deep in its last three matches in the tournament. However, it was a test of character and temperament rather than of skill and strategy.

That it remained unbeaten through seven matches in the tournament despite being far from perfect in five of those reflected the gulf between India and the other teams, and the sub-standard quality of cricket overall.

Abhishek Sharma, the tournament's top scorer, with 314